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A Diary Study on Knowledge Workers' Experiences of LLM Withdrawal

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General FAQ

Why did the study start?

- This study was inspired by last year's Cloudflare outage [1]
- The true relational nature of the technology only becomes visible when it breaks down [2] *(Star, 1999)*
- Therefore, we addressed the RQ: **"What does the withdrawal of LLMs reveal about its pervasiveness in work?"**

How did the withdrawal take form?

- **10 knowledge workers** across various roles (e.g., student, developer)
- **4 days** with voluntary withdrawal of LLM (e.g., ChatGPT, Gemini)
- **Diary study** using web-based diary interface
- **Thematic analysis** of post-interview data

Findings FAQ

Workflow Gaps Revealed Through LLM Withdrawal

Asking People for Help Felt Socially Costly

LLM reliance discouraged asking others for help, weakening social interaction and discussion;
Alternative perspectives sought through other LLMs instead of people.

Processing Web Search Keywords Felt Excessive

Conventional keyword-based web search became cognitively demanding and inefficient after reliance on LLMs.

Loss of Instant Assistance Prompted Delay or Avoidance

LLM unavailability led participants to postpone or abandon task until LLM use was available again.
The absence of immediate LLM access caused frustration.

Difficulties Adapting to the Changing in Work Pace

The loss of LLM speed made tasks feel unexpectedly time-consuming, prompting frustration and schedules adjustments.

Reading and Writing was Met with Lower Standards

Without LLMs, participants lowered quality expectations instead of investing effort in comprehension and revision.

Work Values Reclaimed by Taking Back LLM-Delegated Tasks

Clarity in Work

Participants understood their work more clearly without LLMs, as they had to trace reasoning step by step themselves.

Increased Sense of Ownership

Without LLMs, participants felt greater ownership and pride in outcomes produced entirely through their own effort.

Awareness of Personal Priorities Between Tasks

Reduced efficiency without LLMs led participants to re-evaluate priorities and distinguish skills tha were truly central to their profession.

Inescapable Dependency on LLMs

Too Dependent to Work Without LLMs

Core work abilities were lost in LLM dependency, with further detriment regarding motivation and attitudes toward learning.

Socially Inevitable Use of LLMs

LLMs are not an optional tool but a requirement to remain competitive at work; LLM use as not just a personal choice but as a new social norm.

Discussions FAQ

Note : LLMs are now functioning as implicit social infrastructure.

- With workflow optimized with the **assumption of LLM assistance**, workflow gaps during withdrawal can no longer be considered individual shortcomings.
- In an environment where LLM use is practically inevitable, design can explore room to **appropriate LLM use** to better align with personal and professional values.

References

[1] The Guardian. 2025. Cloudflare down: Internet outage causes widespread disruption to major online services. https://www.theguardian.com/technology/live/2025/nov/18/cloudflare-down-internet-outage-latest-live-news-updates Accessed: 2026-01-19.
[2] Susan Leigh Star. 1999. The ethnography of infrastructure. American behavioral scientist 43, 3 (1999), 377–391.

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